

The Cardinal's Promise

NOTE FOR SCOTT · AUGUST 2026 · ~57,000 WORDS

Scott — this comes with a fresh copy of the manuscript. **The file you have is older**, so a few things are already handled and you can skip them.

Already fixed — please don't spend time here

- **The ending.** The book was closing five separate times. Two closing sections are cut; the back matter after the Epilogue went from 1,630 words to 768.
- **Chapter 26** tightened by 470 words, all scenes kept. Chapter 28 retitled “The Detour.”
- **Two continuity errors:** the first pill was told twice as two different first times, and Lou's age when he met Becky contradicted the dedication.
- **Repetition:** “showing up” cut from 62 uses to 41. Two of the five *Drives* cut.

Open — where you'd help most

- **Chronology.** You're right that it bounces. Part Four runs 2009, 2009, 2006, 2010, 2014, 2011, 2012. Straightening it is welcome.
- **Chapter 19** — five mentor portraits back to back. Readers stall there.
- **Lou is asserted, not dramatized.** Chapter 3 says he had a temper and then never shows it. Horacio is allowed to be difficult, which is why he reads as the most alive person in the book.

One thing to protect

The Epilogue. Every reader so far says the book ends at the cardinal, and that it's earned.